

- **Biting off more than you can chew**

For a first-timer, any structural work or a DIY job of significant scale will likely be too challenging to complete in a profitable timeframe. Start small and be sure to have a building inspection before you buy, so there are no shocks, and cost out the project in full with tradespeople before you take the first swing of the sledgehammer. Which brings us to ...

- **Deadlines**

You don't want to be stuck paying the mortgage on this property for much more than six months – less, if possible – before you put it back on the market. The mortgage repayments, as the project drags, will start to seriously plough into profits. I've seen projects that required more work than anticipated, and more commonly, renovators quibbling over fixtures and fittings, allowing personal preferences to hold them back by investing weeks in creating Pinterest mood boards at the expense of hard yakka. Again, a financial planner or advisor will give you a blueprint as to how far your finances will stretch before you inch into the red.

5. A country property

Must have: Local infrastructure and commerce.

Why? Generous blocks of land and pretty houses that would cost hundreds of thousands of dollars more in the city suburbs, plus grants for first home buyers in some jurisdictions.

Apple pies cooling in the windowsill. Your neighbour Betty popping over with homemade scones. Or, better still, no neighbours within cooee. I could fill this book with stats that show how much cheaper rural homes are than city pads. Return on investment, and being able to pay down a mortgage quicker – and perhaps on a property that in the long term you can rent out, if you ever decide to move back to the city – might bring out your inner country bumpkin.

Universities, hospitals – which pull workers to the area – and road and rail improvements, to enhance city connectivity, are all indicators that a region has potential or is already on the up. These attractive features will